

HABBINSON

PERSONALITY & ENTREPRENEURSHIP SCHOOL

— PARENT INTELLIGENCE REPORT

3 mistakes that close the door

If your child won't open up, stop sitting across from them. Learn how to get your child to talk to you using side-by-side connection, the car, and questions that actually work.

5

ACTION STEPS

6

EXPERT FAQs

3

RESEARCH SOURCES

THE CHALLENGE PARENTS FACE

You sit your child down, look them in the eye, and ask, "So how was your day?" And you get the famous one-word answer: "Fine." Then silence. You know there's a whole world in there. Why won't they let you in?

— THE 30-SECOND ANSWER

3 mistakes that close the door

QUICK ANSWER

Why do kids open up side-by-side? Sitting beside a child removes the pressure of direct eye contact and the feeling of being interrogated. A shared activity gives their hands and eyes something to do, which lowers anxiety. With the spotlight off, the words they were holding back come out on their own.

DO THIS

Better questions than 'how was your day?'

Work through these in order. Small, consistent reps beat one big push.

1**"What made you laugh today?"****2****"What was the most boring part of your day?"****3****"Did anything annoy you today?"****4****"Who did you sit with at lunch?"****5****"If you could redo one part of
today, what would it be?"**

— KEEP AN EYE OUT

The best places to get your child talking

- ☒ The car: no eye contact, a set amount of time, nowhere else to be. Gold.
- ☒ Bedtime in the dark: the lights are off, defenses are down, secrets come out.
- ☒ Side by side at a task: cooking, washing up, building, walking the dog.
- ☒ Shooting hoops or kicking a ball: the body's busy, so the mouth relaxes.

— COMMON QUESTIONS

Quick answers for parents

Why won't my child talk to me about their day?

Often it's the setup, not the child. Face-to-face questions right after school can feel like an interrogation. Try sitting beside them during a shared activity — the car or bedtime — and ask specific, curious questions instead of "how was your day?"

What's the best time to get my child to open up?

The car and bedtime are the two golden windows. Both remove eye-contact pressure and give your child a relaxed, low-stakes space. Kids often share the most when they're not being looked at directly.

What questions get more than one-word answers?

Specific, curious ones: "What made you laugh today?" or "What was the most boring part?" Avoid yes/no questions and the vague "how was your day?" The more specific the question, the longer the answer.

My child shuts down when I give advice. What do I do?

Listen first, fix later — or not at all. Many kids just want to be heard. Try "Hmm, then what happened?" instead of jumping in. Save advice for when they ask, or offer it gently once they feel fully understood.

Does the side-by-side trick work with teenagers?

Especially with teenagers. Teens hate feeling interrogated. A car ride or a late-night kitchen chat, with no eye contact and no pressure, is often the only place they'll really open up.

How do I react when my child tells me something scary?

Stay as calm as you can, even if you're alarmed inside. If you react big, your child learns that telling you hard things leads to drama, and they'll stop. Calm now keeps the door open later.

READING HELPS. PRACTICE STICKS.

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